moved into a strong position.

Instead, the home side took heart and fought back. Cowan made 136, Michael Clarke scored a magnificent 259 not out, and Mike Hussey made 100. They finally declared at 565 for five, and, instead of pushing for the win, we found ourselves batting to save the Test on the fifth day, which we duly did.

Some experts said we should have gone hard for the jugular when we had the chance, persisting with the familiar refrain that the Proteas have been unnecessarily negative; they seemed to forget we were playing a Test series against Australia in Australia. Nothing was going to be easy and straightforward.

The momentum had shifted and the home side took control of the second Test at the Adelaide Oval, once again recovering from 55 for three to reach 550 all out. David Warner crashed 119 in 112 balls, Michael Clarke scored another double century – a remarkable 230 in 257 balls – and Mike Hussey made 103.

We were under pressure and we needed to fight, which we did. Graeme scored a resolute century; Faf du Plessis was playing his Test debut in place of the injured JP Duminy and contributed an important 78; and Jacques Kallis, coming in at No. 9 with a serious hamstring injury, made 58.

These were tough times, testing times. Good teams look strong and settled when things are going well, but it is only the really good teams that remain strong and settled when things are not going their way. Graeme set the tone, as ever, and, collectively, we prepared to draw on all our reserves of courage.

Sometimes simple guts are just not enough. The Australians built on their first-innings lead of 162, pushed hard in the second knock, moved 430 runs ahead and left themselves the better part of a day and a half to bowl us out and take a 1–0 lead in the series. We braced ourselves to bat and to battle to save the Test match and, as we slipped to 45 for four on the fourth afternoon, an emphatic defeat appeared inevitable.